

THIS IS TECHNOLOGY, CULTURE AND SCIENCE WITH A DIFFERENCE, AND THAT DIFFERENCE IS USUALLY ENOUGH TO MAKE MOST NORMAL PEOPLE GO "WTF?"

ALT this month:

The most famous equations, planets that are alive, B&O speakers, an electric hypercar, a smart fan, Game of Thrones, Shazam, Love Death and Robots, and much more...



Fake vacation photo services

If all you really want from a vacation are photos for social media feeds, then it is cheaper to just pay professional photo editors to fake the vacation, and there are services cropping up that cater to this emerging market.

<https://dgit.in/fakevac>

WHAT'S NEW

Why Facts do not change perceptions

In the 1970s, Stanford researchers conducted a series of studies. Undergraduates were asked to sort pairs of suicide notes – one real and one fake. One group was told that they were particularly gifted, while the other was told they did a terrible job. Then, everyone was told that they had been lied to, and that everyone was merely average. After that, both groups were asked to grade their own performance. The group that was told it was special scored themselves higher, and the group that was told they were below average scored themselves lower. Subsequent studies have also demonstrated that perceptions are incredibly difficult to change once they have been formed. In a new



book called *The Enigma of Reason*, Harvard researchers investigate why our minds don't change even when facts are presented. It argues that cooperation is the biggest advantage of the species, and that given the choice, humans will almost

always choose freeloading, as reasoning evolved not to solve abstract problems, but problems that arise from living in a collaborative environment.

<https://dgit.in/fctrsn>

The PowerPoint slide that killed seven people

On 16 January 2003, the Space Shuttle Columbia lifted off from the Kennedy Space Center in Florida for a mission that was scheduled to last a little less than 16 days. During takeoff, a piece of foam broke off from one of support structures, and struck the left wing of the shuttle. An insulation tile on the wing, designed to protect the shuttle from the heat of re-entry was damaged. To assess the damage,

NASA managers sat down with engineers from Boeing, who had a PowerPoint presentation. One



slide showed that they had only tested impacts by pieces of foam that were 600 times smaller

than the chunk that struck Columbia. The Boeing Engineers left feeling confident that they had communicated the risks of re-entry sufficiently. On 1 February, 2003, Columbia exploded with seven crew on board. A professor in communication from Yale University reviewed the slide in question and found problems with it, including a misleading title, an illogical hierarchy of information, and vague terms.

<https://dgit.in/klrppt>



Robot fights Notre Dame fire

A giant robot called Colossus from Shark Robotics helped put out the blaze at Notre Dame by manoeuvring to places that were too risky for the firefighters. The joystick operated robot has a water cannon that can pump out 2500 litres of water every second.

<https://dgit.in/robotff>



Warner signs deal with algorithm

Warner Music has become the first major record label to sign a deal with an algorithm. The deal is with German mood application Endel, which creates custom soundscapes. The deal is for 20 albums over the course of 2019, out of which five have already been released.

<https://dgit.in/algomusic>



To pi or not to pi?

Pi has an infinite series of numbers after the decimal point, but how far should we count? According to NASA scientists, 40 decimal places are enough to accurately measure the circumference of the known universe, with a degree of accuracy that is within the diameter of a single hydrogen atom.

<https://dgit.in/accupi>